

society&the arts CINEMA

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Kohl-rimmed eyes in a permanent-tanned face look into a pair of cat eyes, framed by carefully curled eyelashes, in a union of passion, all make-up sponsored by MAC. The diaphonous dupatta artfully displays the pearls, embellished with rubies the size of giant tear drops, brought to us by Tanishq. The angrakha skims a man

cannot muster, is Harku Bai of Amer, who was never called Jodha. Gowariker has his answer ready in the disclaimer carried at the beginning of the movie—this is just one version of history. There may be others.

Whatever the version though, it has successfully reduced Akbar the Great to Akbar the Lovestruck. As noted historian Shireen Moosvi from Aligarh Muslim University puts it, "The film is doing a disservice to the country's

legacy by saying that one princess could change the course of our history, that Akbar's ideas were not an outcome of Hindus and Muslims living together over a period of time, a natural evolution. Ashoka and Akbar were two emperors committed to reason and logic. To ascribe Akbar's actions to the love for one woman is to undermine our past."

So in the film, Jodha, a modern day princess who seeks a meeting of hearts

ROMEO AND JULIET IN RAJASTHAN **It's a choli ripper set against desert sands, with heaving bosoms and sweaty chests. The prettification extends to facts, turning Akbar the ruler into Akbar the lover.**

cleavage, set off by embroidery from Neeta Lulla's craftsmen. And Akbar romances Jodha Bai in a movie brought to us entirely from writer Haidar Ali and Ashutosh Gowariker's imagination, with an unacknowledged debt to K. Asif's *Mughal-e-Azam* (1960).

The Rs 40-crore *Jodhaa Akbar* is Bollywood's costume central, where more care has been lavished on crafting the 14-kg armour embracing Hrithik Roshan's manly chest than in ascertaining whether Jodha Bai was Akbar's babe or his bahu. It's enough to agitate self appointed custodians of Rajput honour who are frothing at the mouth at Jodha Bai (Aishwarya Rai Bachchan) being portrayed as Akbar's wife. In what has by now become mandatory before the release of any movie which seeks to reflect on politics, past or present, activists of a freshly-floated Rajput organisation called the Karni Sena, demanded that cinema halls in Rajasthan not screen the film—typically none of them had seen the movie. Their argument: Jodha Bai was the daughter of Motaraja Udai Singh of Marwar and was married to Jehangir, Akbar's son. These amateur historians, such as Lokendra Singh Kalvi, chief of the Sena, have been saying they would not have objected to the film if it had been called Akbar-Harku Bai or Salim-Jodha since these names have certain historical credence. Akbar's wife, says Kalvi with the confidence even scholars

